Doing Good by Doing Bad: Reasons Underlying the Failure of International Development Projects (IDPs) †

Lawrence G. Boakye [1, *], Li Liu [2]

[1] *Development Worker, Ghana*

[2] *Senior Lecturer, School of Civil Engineering, The University of Sydney, Australia*

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[*] Corresponding author. *Email address: lawrence_boakye@yahoo.com*

Abstract: Prior studies have identified some factors that cause the failure of International Development Projects (IDPs). However, little to no studies have sought to uncover the reasons that underlie the continuous failure of these projects. By exploring 53 defunct AfDB-funded projects in Ghana and Mali to come out with reasons that facilitated their failure, we provide and extend much needed contextual knowledge on IDP failure by uncovering five (5) underlying reasons responsible for the failure of IDPs, which is a catalyst for further research. Armed with the identification and an understanding of these reasons, we put International Development (ID) institutions and development practitioners in a better position to avoid the development and planning of IDPs that would be doomed to failure from outset.

Keywords: International Development; International Development Projects; Project Failure; Reasons for Failure; Third World

1.0 Introduction

As a result of the advantages that come along with organising a task as a project, such as the freedom to create an organisation more or less from scratch (Hall, 1980), the world is being projectised; several million-dollar development interventions are being implemented in the third world through projects. Such projects, usually referred to as International Development Projects (IDPs), are medium to large size public projects and/or programmes in all sectors of developing countries (the third world) financed by multilateral development banks such as World Bank and regional development banks, United Nations associated agencies, bilateral and multilateral government agencies such as European Union, Non-Governmental Organisations (NGOs) such as Catholic Relief Services and government agencies in developing countries (Youker, 2003). They have thus become important instruments of channelling development assistance into the third world. The intentions of IDPs have always been to do good - to introduce enhanced technologies, improve the livelihood of the underprivileged, promote employment or assist in the development of infrastructure. However, they usually turn out doing bad; they are unable to achieve their aim(s) or make the desired impact. In fact, they fail at an alarming rate that Hermano et al. (2013) commented they have turned project failure into a rule rather than an exception. Why do such IDPs all too often fail to achieve their aim(s) or make the desired impact despite several years of experience in managing projects and the numerous Project Management (PM) certification programmes?"

Whilst many factors might be responsible for the failure of IDPs, we uncover critical reasons that are responsible for their prevalent failure based on empirical analysis of Project Completion Reports (PCRs) of 53 African Development Bank (AfDB)-funded projects in Ghana and Mali. We identify poor project Quality-at-Entry (QAE), weak project structure, poor control mechanisms, weak implementation capability and cognitive bias as the reasons that underlie their failure. By failure, we are referring to the inability of IDPs to produce the desired deliverables or make the desired impact within the allocated time and budget, be it as planned and/or amended. And by management, the authors refer to the means of controlling activities in IDPs towards their desired outcome. Thus, management and implementation are used interchangeably in this paper.

This paper is a catalyst for further research. It goes beyond the ordinary factors of failure to identify what underlies them. It extends knowledge and provides much needed contextual information on project failure for institutions and professionals in the multi-billion International Development (ID) sector where academic research in project management is surprisingly limited (Ika and Donnelly, 2017) - a sector characterised by a paucity of research done on IDP failure. Such information would help ID institutions and development practitioners identify and target key areas in IDP management that need improvement or a focussed and continuous attention so that they could avoid the development and planning of IDPs that are doomed to failure from outset. It therefore makes a key contribution to available International Development Project Management (IDPM) literature.

The rest of the paper is structured thus. The next section, i.e. two, summarises literature on IDPs with a focus on why they fail. The research approach employed for the study is elaborated in section three. In the fourth section, the results are presented and discussed. This section also outlines the research contributions and implications. Section five concludes the paper.

2.0 Why IDPs and Why Study Failure?

IDPs have become useful instruments used in addressing the socio-economic needs of the third world, which often involves poverty alleviation with the usual profit motives of projects often missing (Youker, 2003). Most were originally "hard" type construction-based projects involving civil works with clear goals (Youker, 2003). But in recent times, they have evolved into "soft" projects involving social and human development with "hard" components [(Youker, 1999); (Youker, 2003); (Crawford and Bryce, 2003)] and a very high involvement of stakeholders. Their objectives have thus become less visible and harder to measure giving rise to a myriad of problems that unfold during their implementation. These peculiarities, coupled with the uniqueness and uncertainties associated with projects, create a special challenge in the management of IDPs, a challenge which per Khang and Moe (2008), require an adaptation of the existing Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBoK). No wonder they have been reported to have turned project failure into a rule rather than an exception Hermano et al. (2013), leading to dire consequences for the stakeholder - beneficiary dyad.

That notwithstanding, IDPs stand tall when it comes to channelling development to the third world. Approximately US$3 billion, for instance, is available through donors and international agencies for developmental purposes in Vietnam (Thi and Swierczek, 2010). IDPs will thus remain a dominant means of activating and achieving development in the third world in the foreseeable future. However, irrespective of their usefulness and importance, they are under-researched; academic research in PM under such an important sector is surprisingly limited (Ika and Donnelly, 2017). We are thus yet to fully understand them, which would aid their effective management for desired results.

Failure in real life is more frequent than we would like it to occur (Kharbanda and Pinto, 1996). It therefore comes as no surprise that most IDPs continue to disappoint. This is because aside being challenging and unpredictable endeavours, the environments within which IDPs are implemented are mostly resource-constraint. Failure in itself is not that bad; it offers useful lessons much more than success. But practical on-the-field learning from IDP failures painfully comes at a high cost to all stakeholders more especially because they are implemented in environments that lack adequate necessary resources. As such, as the French adage "one learns by failing" goes, we stand to understand IDPs better if we examine and learn from the challenges that confronted defunct ones instead of quietly filing them away.

We stand to discover what works best in implementing successful IDPs and which approaches are necessary for their effective management by finding out what went wrong and why it went wrong from defunct ones.

2.1 IDP Failure - What Contemporary Literature Tells Us

IDPs are usually identified and developed with the sole involvement of the financing institution with little or no involvement of major local stakeholders, which makes the stakeholders feel side-lined (Youker, 1999). Those who do the planning are, more often than not, therefore not necessarily those who implement the project, leaving the local project manager and team with a full responsibility of the project and very little authority over the resources needed to make the project succeed [(Strachan, 1978); (Avots, 1969); (Youker, 1999)]. These basics of interaction between the financing institution and their hosts make the application of good project management, which can solve most of the problems associated with IDPs, difficult (Youker, 1999). Many problems thus emerge during their implementation making it impossible to, as Freedman and Katz (2007) reported, pinpoint the sole root cause of their failure.

A myriad of factors, running a gamut from poor or ineffective planning that results in weak links between sectoral planning and project identification, project identification/feasibility and formulation as well as project preparation/project appraisal and project implementation (Sahibzada and Mahmood, 1992) and which also results in poor designs that render projects unsuitable to local conditions [see, for example (Agheneza, 2009); (Boakye and Liu, 2016)], lack of flexibility in implementation [see, for example, (Olsson, 2006); (Boakye and Liu, 2015); (Boakye and Liu, 2016)] and lack of local PM capacities [(Nguyen, 2007); (Ika, 2012)] to poor exit strategies, which aids poor ownership of project deliverables by local stakeholders, especially the direct beneficiaries.

There are, however, other "soft" factors responsible for IDP failure. These factors, such as complexity, uncertainty, incompatible host/donor management systems and endemic corruption [see, for example, (Rondinelli, 1979); (Ika, 2012)] are harder to readily identify, sometimes virtually intractable and equally cause or facilitate failure just like the afore-mentioned commonly known factors. The "softer" the IDP, the more complex it becomes; the more complex the IDP, the more challenging it is to implement and thus the higher its susceptibility to failure. Complexity and uncertainty are inherent in projects, particularly IDPs, owing to their nature. But these factors are compounded through the foisting of unwanted or exploitative projects on governments by multinational corporations as well as the usage of culturally incompatible management methods by foreign consultants (Rondinelli, 1979). And because IDP failure become more probable with increased complexity, Whitney and Daniels (2013) believe that a major cause of failure in complex projects such as IDPs is the complexity inherent within the project. IDP success therefore requires mastering numerous challenges in a complex context since implementing projects in different countries with unique legal and political environments, security issues, economic factors, and infrastructure limitations and requirements, increases complexity far beyond that of conventional projects (Freedman and Katz, 2007).

The causes of failure of IDPs therefore appear to be manifested as by-products of the complexity inherent within them and certain managerial traps - traps which Ika (2012) reported are responsible for the problems IDPs encounter as well as their eventual failure. From his standpoint, IDPs all too often get caught up in at least one of the under-listed four (4) traps, not to say all of them together at any given time. And it is only when IDPs break free from these traps, per Ika (2012), that their rate of failure can reduce.

1. The “one-size-fits-all” trap where there is the notion that all types of projects share similar characteristics. Development projects are somewhat experimental and even seemingly routine replications often meet unanticipated difficulties when transferred from one cultural setting to another (Rondinelli, 1979). Moreover, different factors affect IDPs at different stages in their lifecycle. All IDPs cannot therefore be implemented in the same way. Tried and tested methods might even prove difficult to be applied in their management.
2. The “accountability-for-results” trap which occurs when too much emphasis is placed on strong procedures and guidelines, resulting in “accountability for results” to the neglect of “managing projects for results”.
3. The “lack-of-project-management-capacity” trap due to lack of and/or shortages of personnel skilled in project management, as also reported by Nguyen (2007). Too much reliance on foreign expertise in the third world has resulted in the failure to build up required skills for managing projects (Rotner, 1970).

4. The “cultural” trap where there is no consideration of the cultural setting of IDPs. Geographical distances, language barriers and cross-cultural gaps that are typical of an international project’s environment introduce further leadership challenges and additional risks that cause IDP failure (Freedman and Katz, 2007). The impact of such a trap is exacerbated through the usage of inappropriate tools in managing projects (Lawrence and Scanlan, 2007).

3.0 Research Methodology

We sought to explore the reasons underlying the failure of IDPs in this study. And we felt a better way to undertake such a study was to explore real-world defunct projects. Accordingly, to provide a good basis to generate new and further research into IDP failure, we decided to use secondary data. This is because research based on secondary or archived data is promising within the field of project management (Ahsan and Gunawan, 2010); in construction projects alone, 49 journal articles, whose research method employed documentation and record of completed projects, has once been identified out of a review of 101 (Sun and Meng, 2009). Secondary data also allow for true research as they are more publicly available to a larger number of scholars and are generally more objective than even primary survey data because they are free from contamination due to respondents’ perception(s) and/or memories of the phenomenon of interest (Calantone and Vickery, 2009).

3.1 Selection of Case Projects

We sought to study IDPs in Africa. Thus, we purposively narrowed our study to projects that were financed by African Development Bank (AfDB) and further limited it to those implemented in Ghana and Mali. The choice of these two countries was guided by the following criterion as used by AfDB in one of its evaluation reports: whilst Mali is an arid land-lock country, Ghana is a coastal (non-arid) country, as such the two countries face different technical and institutional challenges and would thus generate useful knowledge.

To address the qualitative nature of the study, a search was conducted for Project Completion Reports (PCRs) of defunct projects from archives. The keyword mostly used for the search was project/programme completion report. As at the time of the study, the search yielded 67 PCRs out of which 14 were excluded, leaving 53 for the analysis. Reasons for the exclusion include incomplete reports, duplicated reports, reports in French Language, reports of projects implemented in countries other than Ghana and Mali, and single reports for multinational projects. The PCRs are available at the bank's website, i.e. www.afdb.org, for public access. And they are based on the bank's appraisal/supervision missions' reports, aide memoires, reports from Project Management/Co-ordination Units (PMCUs), project reviews and reports on project closure missions.

3.2 Data Collection and Analysis

A two-step method was developed for the collection and analysis of data. Following Kharbanda and Pinto (1996), Olsson (2004) and Osei-Tutu et al. (2010), an exploratory approach involving an extensive review of the PCRs of the selected case projects was first undertaken to extract reasons reported therein to have caused setbacks or challenges that militated against the success of the projects. Content analysis, which offers a pragmatic method of developing and extending knowledge (Hsieh and Shannon, 2005), was employed in this regard. To increase the reliability of the extracted data, double-data extraction was used to reduce the level of errors in the extraction process. Data extraction was undertaken again about four (4) months after the initial analysis.

After the extraction, the data was analysed using factor analysis by way of Principal Component Analysis (PCA) to reduce it and come out with the underlying structure of the extracted reasons of failure. The analysis was conducted using the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) software. To aid the analysis, the extracted reasons for IDP failure were coded - a code of zero (0) was assigned where the reason was not identified in the PCR to have hindered the success of the project and one (1) assigned where identified otherwise. Before running factor analysis, the Cronbach's alpha of the data was first computed to ascertain how reliable it is. Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) measure of sampling adequacy and Bartlett's Test of Sphericity were also conducted to identify whether the data was suitable to be analysed using factor analysis.

4.0 Results and Discussions

Content analysis of the PCRs of the 53 sampled IDPs yielded various reasons of failure, which were grouped into 14 variables. These are deficient designs, poor quality of project at entry, planning inadequacy, inappropriate procurement methods/systems, exogenous factors, lack of project flexibility, political expediency, bad project management actions, supervision-related issues, lack of appropriate institutional PM capacities, personnel inadequacy/understaffing, lack of project ownership, optimism bias and inadequate support to project.

4.1 Cronbach's Alpha Reliability Test of Variables

The results of this test proved that the set of variables was internally consistent as a group and hence reliable. A score of *.742*, as shown in Table 1.0, was recorded. This indicates a high level of internal consistency of the variables and reliability for analysis.

Table 4.1: Reliability Test of Variables

Reliability Statistics		
Cronbach's Alpha	**Cronbach's Alpha Based on Standardised Items**	**N of Items**
.742	.744	14

4.2 Factor Analysis of Variables

The KMO measure of sampling adequacy was *.643*. This indicates the data was suitable for factor analysis as the value was above the cut-off of .50. The result of the Bartlett's Test of Sphericity, that is, $x^2(91) = 284.131$, $p \lt .000$ also proved an existence of patterned relationships among the 14 variables. These results, presented in Table 2.0, confirmed the suitability of using factor analysis for the identification of the underlying structure of the variables through the grouping of variables that measure similar dimensions.

Table 4.2: KMO Measure and Bartlett's Test

Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin Measure of Sampling Adequacy		**.643**
Bartlett's Test of Sphericity	Approx. Chi-Square	284.131
	df	91
	Sig.	.000

The PCA retained five components (Table 3.0), which measure similar dimensions of the variables analysed and which also represents the reasons that underlie IDP failure. In considering the factor loadings on the five retained components, the time-honoured rule of thumb that considers a substantial loading to be *.40* or higher was employed ("Research 101," 2016). All variables with loadings below *.40* were thus ignored. Of the 14 variables analysed, *political expediency* did not load significantly on any of the components. One variable, i.e. *inadequate support to project*, was also identified to be a complex variable as it loaded significantly onto two different components. But because its loading on component five was higher than that of component one, it was treated as a variable of component five.

Table 4.3: The Identified Underlying Reasons for IDP Failure with their Dimensions and Factor Loadings

	Components				
	1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**
Variable	**Poor Project Quality-at-Entry (QAE)**	**Weak Project Structure**	**Poor Control Mechanisms**	**Weak Implementation Capability**	**Cognitive Bias**
Deficient Designs	.953				
Poor Quality of Project at Entry	.947				
Planning Inadequacy	.833				
Inappropriate Procurement Methods/Systems		.711			
Exogenous Factors		.660			
Lack of Project Flexibility		.635			
Political Expediency					
Bad Project Management Actions			.867		
Supervision-Related Issues			.745		
Lack of Appropriate Institutional PM Capacities				.823	
Personnel Inadequacy/Understaffing				.657	
Lack of Project Ownership				-.608	
Optimism Bias					.826
Inadequate Support to Project	.413				.471

Component one had deficient designs, poor quality of project at entry and planning inadequacy as its dimensions. Each dimension had a high individual factor loading, which is an indication of the extent of impact component 1 has on the failure of an IDP. We named this component *"poor project Quality-at-Entry (QAE)"* as it gave an indication of the measure of inadequacy in the readiness or appropriateness of the project for implementation at outset. The QAE of a project is dependent on the quality of planning and is thus inhibited by factors such as the time taken to plan and prepare the project, failure to learn from past projects, prolonged delays between project feasibility studies and project start-up as well as inadequate investigations such as assessments of risk and mitigation measures (Boakye and Liu, 2016). If the output of a project is to contain quality, then this quality must be properly planned for in the early stages of the project (Kerzner, 1987). The outcome of IDPs is thus dependent on their QAE, which is an emerging construct on the readiness of projects for implementation. This finding confirms the usefulness of QAE. It also explains why a study undertaken by the World Bank's independent evaluation office identified a strong correlation between QAE and successful development outcomes [see (Morra and Thumm, 1997)]. Per the study, out of a total of 1125 projects, 80% of those with adequate QAE were successful as compared to a 35% success rate for those with inadequate QAE.

Component two, which we named "*weak project structure"* had inappropriate procurement methods/systems, exogenous factors and a lack of project flexibility as its dimensions. It was named thus as its dimensions gives an indication of poor project structures. The weaker the structure of an IDP, the more likely it is to fail as IDPs, unlike other conventional projects, are highly complex and unpredictable in nature with closely interconnected activities where a decision to undertake a successive activity depends on the outcome of preceding one(s). Moreover, as already mentioned, all IDPs are also somewhat experimental and even their seemingly routine replications often meet unanticipated difficulties when they are transferred from one cultural setting to another (Rondinelli, 1979).

Two dimensions - bad project management actions and supervision related issues - comprised component three. These dimensions evinced poor control and thus, this component was named "*poor control mechanisms"*. The volatility of the environment makes control mechanisms necessary to anticipate problems, adjust plans, and take corrective action as needed (Bedeian, 1989). "Poor feedback and control mechanisms for early detection of problems" is a major recurring problem in the management of IDPs (Youker, 1999). It has a major impact on IDPs so much so that as per Baker and Jennings (1994), the need for control mechanisms in projects is thus generally unquestioned.

Lack of appropriate institutional PM capacities, personnel inadequacy/understaffing and lack of project ownership make up component four. The necessary skills for effective management of projects have not been successfully developed in the PM-related workforce in developing countries (Nguyen, 2007). Thus, per Ika (2012), the lack-of-project-management-capacity is one trap that all too often is responsible for the problems IDPs encounter as well as their eventual failure. We therefore named this component "*weak implementation capability"*. The capacity to implement a project successfully is tied to the availability of resources and the level of expertise of personnel in PM. But because the third world is resource-constraint and there exists too much reliance on foreign expertise (Rotner, 1970) that has resulted in the failure to build up required skills for managing projects, it comes as no surprise that weak implementation capacity is identified as a reason that underlies the failure of IDPs.

Project ownership has to do with the level of acceptance of a project and/or its deliverable(s) by the stakeholders, most especially beneficiaries. When there is a lack of it, it hampers the smooth implementation of project activities even when the capacity to implement is available and hinders the sustenance of project deliverable(s) as well. A lack of project ownership usually arises due to the failure of project planners to involve/consult stakeholders in the formulation and preparation of projects. It thus facilitates project failure. However, it might have an inverse relationship to implementation capability, hence its negative loading of *-608* as seen in Table 3.0.

Component five, which we named "*cognitive bias"*, is a systematic error common to all humans, a flaw in judgement that arises from errors of memory, social attribution, miscalculations such as statistical errors or a false sense of probability, individual motivations, emotions and limits on the mind's ability to process information [(Mata, 2012); (Dvorsky, 2013); (Cherry, 2015)]. Its dimensions per the study are optimism bias and inadequate support to project.

Optimism bias, originally referred to as unrealistic optimism (Weinstein, 1980), is the tendency of individuals to overestimate the likelihood of positive events and underestimate the likelihood of negative events (Flyvbjerg, 2014). Because of this tendency, IDP planners and practitioners are usually overly confident of positive outcomes. Thus, they pay little to no attention to force majeure and overlook lessons from similar previous projects. This results in over-estimation of project benefits and under-estimation of costs as well as the level of support to be offered to the project. Owing to cognitive bias, Flyvbjerg (2005) reported that project planners and promoters involuntarily spin scenarios of success and overlook the potential for mistakes and miscalculations leading to the pursuance of initiatives that are unlikely to come in on budget or on time, or to ever deliver the expected returns.

4.3 Research Contribution and Outlook

With the world being projectised, Boakye and Liu (2016) believes now is the best time to have a better understanding of IDP failure. They thus made a clarion call for studies to unravel why IDP failure is prevalent. This paper, which is a good response to such a call, has implications for both theory and practice. By highlighting the reasons underlying the failure of IDPs, the paper makes a key contribution to available literature by going beyond the ordinary factors of failure to identify what underlies these factors. It provides and extends much needed contextual knowledge on IDP failure, which is a catalyst for further research. The paper is thus a key contribution to extant literature in project management under the multi-billion ID sector, which has been reported by Ika and Donnelly (2017) to be surprisingly limited.

The study uncovers poor project Quality-at-Entry (QAE), weak project structure, poor control mechanisms, weak implementation capability and cognitive bias as the reasons underlying the failure of IDPs. A practical knowledge on IDP failure, which is useful to avoid the development of IDPs doomed to failure from outset is thus available to ID institutions and development practitioners. Armed with such knowledge, they can increase the chances of success of development interventions in the third world. For instance, cognitive bias is a genuine and biological attribute of humans that is difficult to do away with in developing and planning projects. But its impact on projects could be moderated by employing reference class forecasting, as recommended by Flyvbjerg (2008). As such, with the identification that cognitive bias is an underlying reason for IDP failure, the IDP planner and manager can limit the impact of such a bias by making projections not on the basis of previous personal experience but rather on the basis of actual performance in a class of comparable projects used as a reference.

This study focussed on Ghana and Mali. It limited the case projects to IDPs sponsored by just a single ID institution - AfDB. Increasing the number of case projects across different countries and ID institutions could lead to a much greater contribution to research in project management. The study was also limited to identifying the reasons underlying IDP failure. Further research on the impact of the identified underlying reasons, herein uncovered, on the outcome of IDPs would be beneficial in the quest to improve efforts in curbing failure.

5.0 Conclusion

The paper analysed the underlying reasons for the failure of IDPs in two countries - Ghana and Mali. It justified the need for studies on IDPs and their failure - that IDPs are core to the development of the third world and learning why they have continually failed to make the desired impact is critical to the success of future ones. Then, exploring 53 defunct AfDB projects to come out with reasons that militated against their success, the paper identified that deficient designs, poor quality of project at entry, planning inadequacy, inappropriate procurement methods/systems, exogenous factors, lack of project flexibility, political expediency, bad project management actions, supervision-related issues, lack of appropriate institutional PM capacities, personnel inadequacy/understaffing, lack of project ownership, optimism bias and inadequate support to project inhibit the success of IDPs and thus facilitate IDP failure.

Further research then revealed that poor project Quality-at-Entry (QAE), weak project structure, poor control mechanisms, weak implementation capability and cognitive bias are the underlying structure of the 14 afore-mentioned reasons that cause IDP failure. Thus, we propose that poor project Quality-at-Entry (QAE), weak project structure, poor control mechanisms, weak implementation capability and cognitive bias are the reasons underlying the failure of IDPs.

As already mentioned, failure in itself is not that bad as we learn by failing. We gain wisdom every bit as much from failure as from success since we often discover what works by finding out what does not (Kharbanda and Pinto, 1996). But we cannot continue to learn what is required to facilitate the success of IDPs through practical failures as the cost of learning from real-world IDP failure is painfully high to all stakeholders. It has also been reported that the problem of project failure is not in ability, skill or knowledge but rather in a project system that is almost certainly doomed to failure (Acord, 1999). Exploratory research into what makes IDPs susceptible to failure is therefore key to reducing the chances of failure of future ones. Through the revelation and an understanding of these underlying reasons of IDP failure, ID institutions and development practitioners stand to reduce the chances of failure of their development interventions by concentrating efforts and adopting strategies that would curtail these reasons in the implementation of IDPs. They are therefore better armed to avoid the development and planning of IDPs that would be doomed to failure from outset.

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Authors

Lawrence G. Boakye *is a development worker and an Australia Awards alumnus. He recently graduated with a Master of Philosophy (MPhil) degree from the Project Management Programme of The University of Sydney, Australia where he undertook a research study on why International Development Projects (IDPs) fail. Prior to his postgraduate studies, he was involved in significant development interventions by ActionAid Ghana, World Vision Ghana and African Development Bank in Ghana from which he has drawn useful lessons. Armed with his experience, he seeks to contribute to the interchange of ideas between academia and the International Development (ID) sector so that academic research can have practical outcomes, thereby helping the developing world adopt better managerial approaches in the implementation of development interventions. Lawrence's research is centred on the performance of IDPs with a focus on why they fail.*

Dr. Li Liu *is a senior lecturer in project management at The University of Sydney, Australia. He had his PhD degree from the Australian Graduate School of Management (AGSM). He also holds a master's degree in taxation from the same institution, an MBA and a BE. Dr. Liu has one decade of working experience in systems engineering, project management, business research, management consulting and managing an e-commerce company. He has been published in many international journals including IEEE Transactions on Engineering Management, Project Management Journal, Journal of Information Technology (JIT), International Journal of Project Management (IJPM) and Construction Management & Economics (CME). He has presented at INSEAD and a number of international conferences, including the Project Management Institute (PMI®) Research Conference and the International Conference for Information Systems. Dr. Liu has also served as a reviewer for a number of journals and conferences including MIS Quarterly, JIT, CME, International Conference for Information Systems, European Conference for Information Systems (ECIS) and the PMI® Research Conference. He has been serving as a senior editor for JIT. His research focusses on the performance of infrastructure projects, organisational project management, organisational learning in project organisations, IT/IS project management, organisational control theory and project/programme governance.*

Appendix 1: Description of Identified Factors of IDP Failure following Content Analysis of Project Completion Reports of Case Projects

Factor	Description
Planning Inadequacy	Overlooking certain key elements in project formulation, e.g., lack of feasibility and baseline studies, poor/no assessment of risks and mitigation measures, not incorporating lessons learnt from similar, previous projects as well as no stakeholder and beneficiary input. Effects include ill-defined roles, responsibilities and processes, scope changes as well as unrealistic time-frames, budgets and targets.
Deficient Designs	Designs that are technically weak and which lack relevant details and contingency plans to aid project implementation.
Inappropriate Procurement Methods/Systems	Selecting unsuitable procurement modes such as National Competitive Bidding (NCB) or International Competitive Bidding (ICB) instead of local shopping for relatively smaller contracts, the result of which is lengthy procurement processes.
Bad Project Management Actions	Inappropriate managerial decisions and/or actions during project delivery, e.g. cutting down the scope of a project component without assessing its impact on other component(s), ignoring the project environment during implementation, over-managing project teams with many layers of oversight and bureaucracy, and poor communication in project teams and stakeholders.
Lack of Appropriate Institutional PM Capacities	Weak managerial skills and experience of personnel, as well as weak structural/systemic attributes of institutions to manage projects, e.g., weak project managers, weak ICT base, insufficient vehicles and poor inter-department relations.
Personnel Inadequacy/ Understaffing	Management of projects without the full complement of competent personnel. This results in extra workloads for staff that might not even have the requisite experience.
Inadequate Support to Project	Low level of commitment by host government and other stakeholders to the project evident in the untimely and irregular release of counterpart funds/resources.
Lack of Project Ownership	Project beneficiaries not regarding projects as their own and thus remain indifferent to the project. It usually happens as a result of not consulting and/or involving beneficiaries so as to understand their needs during project planning.
Exogenous Factors	Factors beyond the control of the project management team, e.g. economic downturns, restructuring/relocation of stakeholder institutions, political unrest, conflicts, bad weather conditions, etc. that hinder project implementation and success.
Political Expediency	Making decisions and/or undertaking activities that are convenient to politicians or that will advance the self-serving motives of politicians to the detriment of the project.
Poor Quality of Project at Entry	An unsound project in terms of fineness and appropriateness for implementation at outset.
Lack of Project Flexibility	No element(s) of responsiveness built into projects to enable them respond rapidly to changing conditions.
Optimism Bias	The tendency of being overly-confident of attaining the desired outcome of the planned project/activity and overlooking/underestimating the possibility of experiencing unexpected events which are usually negative during project implementation.
Supervision-Related Issues	Issues such as no or irregular project supervisions, poor skill-mix of supervisory team, wrong timing and limited duration of supervisions.

Appendix 2: Table of Case Projects Used for the Study

No	Ghana	Mali
1	Agricultural Sector Rehabilitation Programme	Baguinéda Irrigation Scheme Intensification Project
2	Bonsa Tyre Rehabilitation Project	Basic Education Support Project
3	Capacity Building Programme for the Supervision of Aviation Safety in West & Central Africa (COSCAP Programme)*	Education Project III
4	Cocoa Rehabilitation Project	Fourth Structural Adjustment Programme
5	Community Forestry Management Project	Good Governance Support Project
6	Economic Reform Support Operation Loan	Growth & Poverty Reduction Strategy Support Programme
7	First Line of Credit to Agricultural Development Bank	Health Facilities Strengthening Project in Koulikoro, Nara & Niafunke
8	Health Services Rehabilitation Project	Integrated Management of Invasive Aquatic Weeds in West Africa*
9	Industrial Sector Adjustment Loan	Manantali Dam Project
10	Inland Valleys Rice Development Project	Middle Bani Plains Development Programme
11	Institutional Support to Two Ministries	Project for the Support to the Seed Sector
12	Integrated Management of Invasive Aquatic Weeds in West Africa*	Project in Support of Preventive Desert Locust Control in 4 CLCPRO Member States*
13	Kpong Irrigation Project	Project to Reform System & Means of Payment in UEMOA Countries*
14	Livestock Development Project	Regional Solar Energy Centre for CEAO Project
15	Mechanised Rain-fed Cotton Production Project	Rural Development Support Project of the Daye, Hamadja & Kurioume Plains
16	Nasia Rice Project	Second Line of Credit to BNDA
17	Nerica Rice Dissemination Project*	Second Line of Credit to Mali Development Bank
18	Palm Oil Milling Factories Project	Strengthening of the SAP
19	Poverty Reduction Project	Structural Adjustment Programme III
20	Poverty Reduction Support Loan	Supplementary Programme to the Structural Adjustment Programme III
21	Project for the Creation of Sustainable Tsetse & Trypanosomiasis Free Areas in East & West Africa*	Support Project for Health & Social Development Programme
22	Rural Financial Services Project	Women's Empowerment & Poverty Reduction Support Project
23	Second Economic Rehabilitation Support Loan	
24	Second Line of Credit to the Agricultural Development Bank	
25	Second Poverty Reduction Support Loan	
26	Small Scale Irrigation Development Project	
27	Subri Industrial Plantation Project	
28	Tertiary Education Rehabilitation Project	
29	Third Line of Credit to Agricultural Development Bank	
30	Third Poverty Reduction Support Loan	
31	Women's Community Development Project	

*****Multinational Project